Utopia

In many ways, Thomas More is one of the most attractive figures of the Renaissance. He was a scholar, a practical politician and statesman, and a martyr who was killed by Henry VIII on account of certain political and religious disputes. What he's most known for nowadays is the fact that he authored *Utopia*, which is one of the great works in the tradition of Western political thought. It narrates or describes what an ideal society would be like from the perspective of a believing Christian at the time of the Renaissance. In many respects, it is an encapsulation of the Western tradition of political theory. Like his friend Erasmus, Thomas More was remarkable for his tolerance and conservatism, not in its contemporary sense, but rather in his reluctance to change, not specifically with reference to particular political issues, but mostly his religious conservatism.

He maintained his position as a believing Catholic during the early stages of the Lutheran Reformation and wrote books against Luther. Like Erasmus, he attempted to find a middle ground which would allow the Catholic Church to be changed internally without generating religious schism and religious war, which they both feared. His religiously motivated conservatism concerned larger religious issues rather than particular political decisions. His opposition to heresy, however, also included support for persecution. He was very personally pious. He was a man remarkable for his own virtue, for the fact that as a politician he was extremely honest, and yet at the same time he was very much afraid of change. Thomas More has in mind in his *Utopia* a static society which is immune to change.

In some ways, Thomas More thinks that a good society is one which will be immune to history. While working for Henry VIII, he eventually became Lord Chancellor of England. When the Lutheran Reformation began, and Luther criticized the Catholic Church and the Catholic sacraments, Henry was still on good terms with the pope and attempted to support Catholicism. The book of 1521 called *The Defence of the Seven Sacraments* is directed against Luther. More assisted with it, although the extent of his contribution is uncertain; it cannot simply be attributed to More rather than Henry VIII. What is important about Thomas More is the fact that he represents a summation of the tradition of Western political thought and moral thought, and he's trying to bring together, to braid together the traditions that come out of Jerusalem and Athens, taking what is best in both, and yet maintaining a fidelity to the tradition that comes out of Jerusalem over the tradition that comes out of Athens. In other words, God wins all ties.

He is trying to braid Athens and Jerusalem together, and *Utopia*, which is his most famous work, borrows directly and heavily from the tradition of Greek political thought in particular. In the first case, he's obviously indebted to Plato. He's indebted to Plato because much of *Utopia* is derived from the *Republic*. There are also deviations from the scheme that Plato offered in the *Republic*, but he borrows the idea of an ideal society: a perfect world and political order in which all change has been eliminated and in which everything is operating according to its best capacity. He also borrows an otherworldly tendency to criticize this world by ideal standards. That's certainly something that he has in common with Plato.

In *Utopia*, Thomas More makes other concessions to the Platonic tradition, things like feminism. He allows women to get the same education as men. They are both responsible for running the state, but in particular for defending the state if it is attacked. Like Plato, More in his *Utopia* abolishes private property, and this is a more important issue than it might appear on first reading. Thomas More advocated a sort of communism. He wanted to abolish money, and he wanted to abolish commerce. He thought commerce and money had a bad ethical influence on society. Like Plato, he thought that it distracted people's attention, distracted people's passions, and caused internal strife to a political order. Thomas More writes *Utopia* in 1516, the Renaissance is well underway, the era of the nation-state is here, the New World has been discovered.

The idea of abolishing commerce, the idea that commerce is leading us down the road to perdition, is in the pejorative sense utopian, in the sense that you could never possibly eliminate that. But what's important about Thomas More is that he can see that the changes that Western culture is undergoing, changes not just in its understanding of geography and the world, but changes in science, changes in religion, and religious schism are all leading us away from a blessed political and moral state. Thomas More wants to bring us back to that. He does not intend *Utopia* as a real, live possibility. In other words, he doesn't think that we could change England either this year or a hundred years from now and turn it into something that's utopian. Like Plato's *Republic*, More's *Utopia* is intended as a sort of yardstick.

We may not find anything in this world that's perfectly one yard long, but the yardstick will allow us to figure out how long an individual thing that we find in the world is. Plato wants us to use his *Republic* as a kind of political yardstick against which various real political orders can be measured and their deficiencies identified. Thomas More intends *Utopia* to be used in quite the same way. He does not anticipate that this world would become perfect, that we could have a utopian society. But *Utopia* does give the Christian humanist a standard by which to look around at the contemporary governments in the world and find them lacking.

“You have been weighed in the balance and found wanting.” That is the way More looks at the contemporary political order, and his way of articulating it is to give us this new utopian construct. His borrowings from Plato are not limited to the *Republic*. The intellectual genealogy of Thomas More's *Utopia* also leads to Plato's *Laws*. Plato changed his political thinking quite considerably from the middle period in which he wrote the *Republic* to the end of his life. The last dialogue is called the *Laws*. It's also one of the longest of the dialogues. That is an attempt to reformulate his conception of political order. In Plato's *Laws*, many concessions are made to the imperfections of human nature, which More lifts wholesale from that part of Plato.

The origin of some of More's ideas lies in the *Laws*, not just the *Republic*. In addition to borrowing from Plato, More also borrows from Aristotle. In some ways this is unavoidable, because Aristotle has such a pervasive influence on the Western tradition, particularly on Western Christianity in the Middle Ages.

He borrows from Aristotle, for example, ideas like the mean. Aristotle in the *Nicomachean Ethics* emphasizes that virtue is a mean between two vices. What he

means by that is that extremes of human conduct are the ones that get us into trouble. More adopts that idea, keeping it consistent with his conception of sin and God's distinction between right and wrong. For the most part, he thinks Aristotle is right. The most important example in *Utopia*, where More adopts an Aristotelian position, is in the way in which religion is presented. In More's *Utopia*, in this Utopian society, there is a plurality of religious beliefs and people are not persecuted on account of their religion.

Of course, this is an implicit criticism of the entire state of Western Europe and the tradition of Western Christianity. People should not be persecuted for their religious beliefs. More says it only drives people into hypocrisy, and then you have a worse problem. Then you have hypocrites buried within your church. Far better for you to allow people to say what they have on their mind and not persecute them for that. In some ways, that's a highly religious idea. More says that it would be a problem in an ideal society if we had people who were atheists. In *Utopia*, atheists are looked upon with great disfavor, but they are not burned, they are not imprisoned or tortured, merely for their beliefs. Atheists are prohibited from holding public office, and they're also prohibited from giving testimony because you have to swear by God, and if you don't believe in God, then it seems to undercut the force of an oath.

The key thing for More, though, in his view of atheism, is that that would be an example of transgressing the Aristotelian mean from a moderate amount of religious zeal and religious insight to none whatever. It is very important to avoid atheism, not just because it endangers our soul and prevents salvation, but also because in a purely pagan, rational way, it is an unacceptable approach to divinity. On the other hand, and this is a very important thing that can be gleaned out of the text of *Utopia*, too much religious zeal is a sin and an evil. It conflicts with Aristotle's idea of the mean, but it also conflicts with true Christian piety.

This is quite a remarkable observation from Thomas More. He is a Catholic saint. Sanctity is not foreign to him. He's an extremely holy and honest individual. In addition to that, he was a martyr. He died rather than give up his religious principles for that reason. It is quite surprising, perhaps in some ways paradoxical for us to find that he thinks that an excess of religious zeal is an evil, is a transgression. He gives the following example: When the island of Utopia is first introduced to Christianity, some of the people take it with an unreasonable and unacceptable and unchristian amount of zeal, and they begin to become persecuting, bullying, hectoring people who are constantly threatening other people with their sinfulness, threatening them with God's condemnation and with eternal damnation.

They are causing a civil disturbance. The account approves of the Utopian magistrate who had such a man punished and removed from the public sphere, requiring him not to recant his religious beliefs, but to hold them with a greater degree of moderation. There are plenty of Catholic heresies and schisms within the church, and the development of Lutheranism is only a year or two away, which is going to be a tremendous schism, and then the entire Protestant Reformation. What More is saying here is that virtue is a mean between two vices even when it comes to religion. Too little religion is a gross and obvious evil, but he emphasizes that too much religion is, and that in fact a proper understanding of religion makes people more peaceful, more sociable, more docile and social in that respect.

When people begin to hector others, when they adopt the position of Savonarola, then they go past the boundary, go past the Aristotelian mean, and then properly, even without the insight of scripture, it is proper for the Utopian magistrate to punish such a person. This is only one of the many borrowings that More makes from the Aristotelian tradition. That is quite a large concession. He will never let Aristotle or Plato interfere with his understanding of biblical religion or Christianity. As a Christian humanist drawing on Athens and Jerusalem, he readily acknowledges the classical tradition insofar as it overlaps with Christianity. For that reason, he makes his arguments accessible and plausible to a far wider audience than he would have otherwise.

In addition to the golden mean, More borrows the idea of the family from Aristotle. In the *Republic*, Plato abolishes private property and the private family among the guardians. Aristotle says Plato is wrong. Aristotle says in the *Politics* that the family is the minimal unit of society. More lifts that and takes it because it's so much more consistent with scripture and with Christian traditions. He lifts that right out of Aristotle's *Politics* and drops it into *Utopia*. There are a good number of important borrowings from both Aristotle and Plato. Knowledge of the political thinking of both authors makes it easier to understand what it is that More is choosing to borrow from that tradition, and what he's leaving out.

In some cases, what he leaves out is as important as what he puts in. There are further elements that More includes in his borrowings from the classical tradition.

In the first case, there's a very strong element of Epicureanism. Epicureanism is the philosophical doctrine that pleasure is the only good. More adopts that, which is a strange thing for a Christian state to adopt, but only up to a point, within the bounds of natural reason and also within the bounds of revealed religion. Pleasure is a good thing, provided it meets both of those two standards. So, for example, in *Utopia*, the Utopian people like simple pleasures that are unmixed with any kind of sin. They're fond of music, they're fond of flowers, they're fond of beautiful things, but this loving of beauty does not move to the level of vanity.

These are always simple and natural pleasures. What he is doing in some respects is retreating from the tradition of Christian asceticism that we find in monasticism. More himself practiced considerable mortification of the flesh. He was quite an ascetic individual, but he held that asceticism would make no sense if it did not serve some divine purpose. No divine purpose is served by abolishing the simple and natural pleasures which God has offered to human beings. This is a balanced and harmonious conception of what human beings might become, limited always by a Christian understanding of right and wrong, and constrained by certain borrowings from the classical tradition. Yet, the way in which More fuses them is in some ways a very attractive kind of whole. That is one of the nice things about More.

It doesn't have quite the same level of other-worldliness found in Meister Eckhart, for example. Yet it is consistent with most of our basic intuitions about the human condition, that beauty is not a bad thing if it doesn't cause us to engage in any other transgression, that pleasure is not a bad thing so long as it isn't connected to sin. A very plausible set of arguments.

More's Utopians accept this pretty much in its totality. In addition to Epicureanism, More's *Utopia* borrows from the tradition of Roman Stoicism. What's important here is that, like Stoicism and Christianity, More's Utopians are making cosmopolitan moral claims. In other words, for the Stoic philosopher, the cosmos is his polis. That's what makes him cosmopolitan. The world is his city. He is a citizen of the universe, so are the Utopians. They follow natural reason and natural law, and when they get access to revealed religion, they absorb it very readily because their reasonably constructed system allows them to develop in an uncorrupted fashion, makes them likely vehicles for Christian faith. Thus much has been borrowed from the tradition of Athens in *Utopia*.

Still, the Athenian tradition, the tradition of Greek philosophy, is the junior partner in *Utopia*. In fact, the dominant majority partner is the tradition of intellectual and spiritual life that comes from Jerusalem. There are a number of departures from the Athenian tradition that we see in this tradition from Jerusalem.

The first and most obvious is the idea of sin. Plato and Aristotle don't talk much about sin. It's not within their vocabulary of moral discourse. In More's view, this leads to certain characteristic errors, particularly of the Platonists, for whom he has a very high regard. In the ideal order of Plato's *Republic*, knowledge of the Form of the Good enables the philosopher-king to order society properly and give everyone a good education. The perfected order is expected to overcome evil and transgression. More is far more realistic than that. He is not willing to believe that human beings are perfectible. The belief that human beings are not perfectible is, in fact, another way of formulating the idea of original sin.

If you think that people are perfectible, you are a Greek. If you think that human society cannot be perfected no matter how many laws we pass and no matter how many institutions we change, then, like it or not, one way or another, you believe in sin. More believes in sin, and he's willing to become quite explicit about it. His belief in sin means that people are not perfectible. Even in an ideal society, even in a utopia, it is necessary to have courts, laws and judges. These play little part in the idealized order of Plato's *Republic*, where proper education and rule are expected to overcome wrongdoing.

More regards this as contrary to human nature. Human beings will do bad things no matter how you educate them, no matter what kind of society you draw up. You have to accept that fact. It is the human condition. This is a borrowing not from Athens but from Jerusalem, and this borrowing runs right to the core of his argument because in addition to having laws and courts and provisions for transgression, More has a number of other things written into his expectations about the world. First of all, there will be slavery.

In particular, slavery is imposed as punishment for deeds that would receive a death sentence in other societies. More was an essentially just, generous and kind-hearted man, but he was also a practical politician. He had spent a great deal of time as a judge and a remarkably honest judge. He was well known for his refusal to take bribes in an age when taking bribes was not unusual for a case. Reflection led More to ask: “Is the society I am upholding actually a good society?” At the time More was writing, the penalty for theft in England was death. More questions whether convicting people and sentencing them to be hanged is truly the right response. Perhaps this is too harsh a punishment.

Perhaps the fault lies not in the people being condemned, but in institutions, laws and the way society is organized. One of the great contributions that More makes to the traditions of Western political thought is the idea that maybe society shares some of the blame for the practical evils that we find in our system of laws and courts.

More wants to try and solve some of these problems. One solution is that no lawyers are allowed in *Utopia*. More says that any law worth having is one that everybody understands. If everybody understands it, there is no point in having a lawyer twist it. People can come and speak for themselves. The magistrates are remarkable for their probity and honesty and they don't need prosecuting and defending attorneys. People say what they have to say, and the magistrate manages to discover the truth, which matters in utopian courts. In addition to not having any lawyers, the laws are very simple and few and that way everyone understands what laws govern them.

More thinks it a very evil thing back in Renaissance England that most people didn't know what laws they were obeying. Modern laws can suffer from the same problem: people do not always know the laws they must obey. It has the same sort of characteristic defects and it succumbs to the same sort of criticism. What kind of law obliges me to obey if I do not understand it? More wants few laws, wants everyone to understand them, and wants everyone to speak for themselves. This way we avoid a great deal of the evil that is built into a legal system and we come closer to meeting the standards of truth and for More that is going to be of utmost concern.

There are no lawyers and few courts, and there is always hope. People are not sentenced to death except for those that have repeatedly offended, for whom no further remedy seems possible. More dislikes the death penalty but he sees it as a regrettable necessity under certain circumstances. Instead, offenders can be punished by being made slaves, whom he calls “bondmen.” They are given a period of time in which they are forced to do onerous and menial and unpleasant tasks, but the possibility is always there that if they behave themselves and if they do not transgress further and if they bear their punishment properly with the proper understanding of their chastisement, they may be released from their bondage and reintegrated into society. This is a groping towards the idea of rehabilitation, the idea that people's sins can be repented of, the idea of forgiveness which is central to Christianity has been built right into this legal system.

But a legal system has to be constructed because sin is there and it's there for good. More is walking a fine line between Athens and Jerusalem, between his hope for human perfection and his understanding that it is impossible to completely perfect society. That's one of the great legacies of the tradition that comes out of Jerusalem.

In addition to these ideas about laws there are several important ideas about pleasure and religion. Hedonism is advocated by Utopians but only within the bounds of scripture and only within the bounds of reason. On the other hand there is a certain degree of asceticism which is exclusively the product of religion. There are two groups of people who engage in public service as a means to glorify God and they do it because they think that by sacrificing things in this world, by sacrificing worldly pleasures, they will get transcendental rewards and that God will favor that sort of behavior. The more worldly group, though still hardly profane, eats meat and gets married and does various kinds of

difficult public service. The other kind remains chaste, they do not eat meat, they only eat vegetable food and they are thought of as being holier but not quite as wise as the ones that allow for a certain degree of human creature comforts.

By inventing this category of people that are especially blessed and especially devoted towards divinity who do practically good things in this world, he is answering the criticisms that have been leveled against medieval monasticism. More holds that devoting oneself to God is a fine thing, Giving up worldly cares and profane, day-to-day concerns is admirable, but doing it exclusively within the domain of a cloister and to have no practical effect on the world around you, is by itself not the best way of devoting yourself to God. The idea associated with Plato's *Euthyphro* can be expressed as follows: piety honors God through service to human beings.

More's point is that his religious volunteers will be doing honor to God by doing service to men, not by just praying within the cloister, it is a practical kind of virtue and that's what More is driving us towards. In one sense he is a child of not just the Renaissance but also the classical tradition, he wants people to practically do things in this world. At the same time he is not neglecting the spiritual side of things, he says the way in which you can best give honor to God is by helping human beings. He answers the criticism that had been leveled by some people about the inutility of monasticism without undermining the intent behind it. The spiritual purification that one gets from that can also be gotten from practical things in this world. Now in addition to borrowing things like that, he borrows the just war doctrine from Aquinas.

Christians on the whole are not very violent at least in the theological sense and yet there have been certain Christian thinkers who have tried to sketch out the circumstances under which violence is permissible or perhaps a moral obligation. This is the idea of a just war. Wars of aggression are unjust but wars of defense are for example just. More picks this doctrine up and the Utopians while they hate war will in fact go to war if they are sufficiently provoked and they will go to war under three circumstances. One to defend themselves, two to defend a friendly country and this is not the same thing as a country with which they have a treaty. The Utopians do not sign treaties because they do not trust them.

They reason that honest and peaceful people would not need to draw up a treaty. Duplicitous, dishonest and corrupt people, on the other hand, would draw one up and then break it. What is the point of treaties? Their position is simply that they do not invade others. The Utopians go to war if they are invaded, if a country with which they have friendly relations is invaded, or to deliver a weak state from tyranny. They do so only to achieve good moral ends. They do not engage in wars of aggression or conquest.

In some ways, *Utopia* is a giant co-educational monastery. It is a very strict and very religious sort of a life that is carefully kept within limited rules and yet these rules do not completely drive people towards other worldliness, do not completely drive people towards asceticism. More in some ways has one foot in the Middle Ages and one foot in the Renaissance and in some ways he's straddling the line between the two. He has that same yearning for a perfect stasis, for a perfectly well-ordered society, for a moral society and if that were to happen society would freeze up. He longs for that perfect undynamic stasis.

What is left out in More's *Utopia* is in some ways as important as what gets put in. There is no noble lie in More's *Utopia*. In Plato's *Republic*, the rulers use a noble lie or useful myth to persuade the ruled to accept their assigned roles, bridging the distinction between the gold and bronze classes. That doesn't happen in More's *Utopia* and here's the reason why. All human beings are equal in the sight of God. Human equality as an important value in Western political thought is closely, inextricably bound up with the history of Christianity.

It is impossible for there to be such a gulf between the rulers and the ruled that we would need a special set of myths in a Christian Commonwealth. That is only going to happen in a platonic world where God isn't there to equalize all human nature.

There are two parts to the book. The first was actually written last. The first part is called the “Dialogue of Counsel” and that's where we get introduced to Raphael Hythloday. He's a mariner who has been across the world. He has a wide knowledge of geography and politics and he's an exceptionally learned man for a practical man and that's the key focus there. The Renaissance emphasis on a man being able to do all things, to be both an explorer and a political theorist and a practical politician. All of them are brought together in Raphael but strangely enough it turns out that Raphael, the key figure in More's *Utopia*, has a rather contemplative rather than practical preference. He has been a mariner. He's been all around the world and in particular he has been to Utopia and he's the one who's going to come back and tell us what Utopia is like.

In the Dialogue of Counsel, More and another listener suggest that Raphael, being intelligent, learned, well traveled and well schooled, should work for a king or prince. He could give good advice on statecraft and improve practical politics in Europe. Raphael replies: “The active life would only get me killed, and I could do no one any good.”

Raphael gives the example of theft being a capital crime: capital punishment for theft is far too harsh a sentence. In fact, it causes people to commit murders they wouldn't commit because they have nothing to lose. But in addition to that, it's simply unjust, and unkind, and lacking in mercy. Raphael says that the problem with this society lies not in the fact that you have theft, but lies in the fact that you have gold and silver, and you have greed and luxury. That's what causes theft. The cause of theft is the improper organization of society, at least for most of the cases.

Raphael regards pride in imposing many death sentences for theft as a terrible evil. Your understanding of right and wrong has been corrupted by the corrupt society in which you live. He imagines being in a royal council where advisers offer various ways to expand the king's domain. Raphael would give no such advice. He would say: “Your kingdom is already the right size. Governing it well is difficult enough. Rather than adding to your state, why not do a better job with what you have?” His listeners concede: “You are right. No one will listen to you.”

If you are a minister of state, and you tell an ambitious, proud ruler that he should do a better job with what he has rather than trying to extend his domain, no one will listen to you. You will find yourself in hot water. After two or three examples come up like this, they grudgingly concede that he is probably right. It may be that a good man cannot

give good advice in politics. It could be that the way of the world is such that Machiavellian leaders and Machiavellian advisors are the ones that get heeded. Perhaps it is best for a man to make his feelings and opinions known through the medium of lovely dialogues like this.

Thomas More's actual life is relevant here. This book is written while More is away in the Netherlands on a diplomatic mission, and he is thinking about entering the king's service for the remainder of his life, and he doesn't want to. It is very clear that More wants to go back to the library and read more sacred books, and he would like to think a lot, and he would also be willing to do something to earn a living, say be an honest judge or something like that, but he doesn't want to be the Chancellor of England, which is something like being the Prime Minister of England.

Because he desperately does not want this job, naturally he gets it. He's stuck being an advisor to Henry VIII, who is not remarkable for his saintliness. In some respects the difficulties that Raphael is gesturing at here in the first part of *Utopia* are in fact the same difficulties that More himself will find when he goes into practical politics, and particularly working for someone like Henry VIII, he is going to encounter many difficulties and undertake this in some ways for platonic reasons, not because he himself wants this kind of power, but rather because if he doesn't, someone worse will end up doing this.

While meditating on these problems, he generates the second half of the book, while he's away on this diplomatic mission, and we find here the details of Utopian life are remarkably like a perfect England. It turns out that Utopia is an island just like England, and it turns out it has a large capital city, which is remarkably like London, and it's next to a river that's remarkably like the Thames. He is not suggesting that we can perfect England, but rather that this is what England would be if its corruptions were eliminated. It gives us a yardstick by which to judge contemporary politics. There are 54 cities, and they are of roughly identical size, and they have roughly identical buildings.

Apparently, there's not much innovation in architecture, and all the people wear roughly identical clothes. This is a utopia that would only appeal to someone that comes out of that tradition of Christian asceticism. In other words, there's not much variety. There's not much entertainment value, at least insofar as we might think of things like architecture or dress or paintings as being valuable independent of religious limitations. More was very strict about the religious limitations he would impose on this. If you want lovely clothes, that's an example of vanity. Religion will not allow that. If you want a house that's better than other people's, religion will not allow that as well. Do not be house proud.

Be soul proud. So, More says his 54 cities, which are largely identical with identical buildings, is his idea of a perfect society. Within these cities, politics is organized in a hierarchical way that he thinks mirrors the natural hierarchy of society.

The family is the minimal unit of society, and the eldest male speaks for the whole family. The idea of the individual as being the minimal unit of society, that's not going to become important until the Enlightenment. There is not yet a robust idea of individuality, so the oldest male head of household, the paterfamilias, represents the entire family. An urban household normally includes ten to sixteen adults, in addition to

children. Several generations live together in an old-fashioned extended family. Each thirty families elect a magistrate called a philarch. Each ten philarchs and their households are placed under a higher magistrate traditionally called a tranibor. In addition, a prince rules each city and is elected by the philarchs.

These magistrates are remarkable, first of all, for their intelligence. The Utopians love knowledge. They spend almost all their time thinking and reading and studying. This is quite a utopian society. The philarchs are very honest. They're remarkable for their honesty and for their intelligence. In addition, it is assumed that they will choose virtuous princes. They will not get us involved in foreign escapades. Very much different from the hereditary monarch he works for. Who would vote for Henry VIII? If you had a choice, you would likely vote for somebody else. He is implicitly saying that hereditary monarchy contains many evils.

More works for such a ruler without losing sight of these evils. What he says and what he does not say can both be damning.

In terms of the economy, he is also intriguing. He emphasizes the importance of labor, an idea that will become central in English political economy, particularly in Locke and later theories of value: valuable things in the world come from work. It actually has utopian and Christian roots. Money is abolished in domestic exchanges. Instead, gold and silver are used for chamber pots in order to bring them into disrepute. In addition, gemstones are given to babies because they're shiny and pretty. The idea being that children naturally give up the things of infancy as they get a little bit older and smarter. The idea is that he wants to bring gold and silver and gems into disrepute.

The Utopians use no money in their domestic exchanges. They are beyond commerce in that respect. There are markets, but nothing is sold. They're large storehouses and everybody or every male head of household comes every day or every week whenever he needs supplies and is given whatever he wants in whatever quantity he wants because no one hoards anything because there'll be plenty more there when you go back next week. There's no need for people to be covetous. There is no need for greed. They don't have to pay anything for it. Just bring home what you need.

Everyone brings home what they need. All 30 families eat together in large communal meals. It creates community feeling but also allows elder people to supervise the younger. When people sit down to dinner, it's always an odd even mix of the elder and the younger and the elder and the younger. That means that the young people never get out of hand at dinner. They never become boisterous or difficult because they always have their elders on both sides of them. There's no place to go. Decorum is maintained. The food is wonderful. It saves a great deal of time. People have the burden of oppression lifted from them in many respects. They don't have to take care of their own little nuclear family whether they can or not.

Everyone gets fed. He thinks this is quite consistent with Christian religious tradition. In addition to that, everyone has to work.

More lives at a time when the landed aristocracy includes people who remain idle. They have a whole crew of retainers behind them that do nothing but get into trouble. Then there's, of course, a large chunk of society which has to work six days a week, 12 and 14

hours a day to support themselves and the rest of society in luxury. More wants to abolish that. His principle is: “If you do not work, you do not eat.” Everyone in More's *Utopia* has a skill or a trade. Most of them have two. Because everyone works, they are able to reduce the work day to six hours a day. In other words, he is looking to be kind and merciful towards all people and to remove the inequalities and oppression that are characteristic of the society he finds himself in. He argues that only by making everyone work and expecting everyone to work can everyone have a happy and productive life.

No one is covetous because they always have what they need. They can't get other kinds of clothing. There's only one style. They can't get other kinds of house. Households cannot remain in the same home permanently. Each family will stay in its house for 10 years. At the end of 10 years, they all change houses. The idea being that no one gets too attached to things of this world. Whether this is a good idea in practice is doubtful.

But in theory, he's gesturing at the idea that we should not be too caught up in things of this world. Instead, what we should do is try and move our thoughts from this world to the next. For that reason, prior to their six-hour work day, the Utopians like to go to lectures. Every morning before daybreak, many Utopians attend public lectures. The Utopians love it. Those that aren't inclined towards learning do a little extra work. People approve of that. Those who may become eminent in learning are, by common consent, turned into philarchs and tranibors and the magistrates of the society. Their ambassadors are drawn from the scholarly class, and their professional scholars and the priests are drawn from the scholarly class. More makes a very telling remark somewhere in *Utopia* where he says that their priests are exceptionally holy and therefore very few.

Women can also be priests in More's *Utopia*. Sex is not a barrier to holiness. These changes preserve the old hierarchies, but relinquish attachment to worldly things. We give up on the idea that a happy life is one where you get the most stuff. The happy life is the one in which you are most closely connected to God, in which you do not transgress and do not engage in any evil towards your fellow man. That can only be done if everyone works and everyone pitches in. A nice and, in some ways, quite inspiring idea.

Certainly, later Utopian socialist thinkers are going to derive a lot of their ammunition from this kind of thinking. In foreign policy, the Utopians hate war and avoid it when they can, but when they have to have a war, they do it and they go in to win. Since they have been keeping their money in reserve, they don't use any money, they don't use gold or silver or gems, they can pay mercenaries the largest possible wages. They think it's a great thing because they say that any group of people that would professionally kill people should be encouraged to go get themselves killed. He says that would be a benefit to the entire human race. If we just get them to all kill each other, the Utopians will pay for it.

The grim logic is that if the mercenaries kill one another, the Utopians can pay for it. Only those who come back need to be paid; if half return, only half are paid, so very high wages become affordable. The mercenaries evoke the Swiss, who were the most famous mercenaries in Europe in More's time. He thinks mercenaries and mercenary peoples should be gotten rid of as soon as possible. This is a good reason to keep gold and silver

away from the populace because you always have this tremendous treasure trove. In addition to that, when they engage in a war, they always put a large bounty on the head of their enemy.

They really pay it because they found this to be a very easy way of winning a war. A modern equivalent would be a million dollars on the opposing king's head and a hundred thousand dollars on each minister: such incentives could quickly undermine that society. That society has gold and silver and greed and corruption. They can't do that with the utopian people. The Utopians would laugh at them at such a suggestion.

Beyond foreign policy, their religion is also interesting. They have brought Christianity in recently because they hadn't had access to it prior to that. But they had managed to work out what you might call deistical or natural religion on their own. They had an idea of a creator. They had worked out certain of the ideas of natural religion found in the tradition of Greco-Roman antiquity. But they had been arrested at that phase of development until Christianity comes in. Once Christianity comes in, it begins to make very quick and very powerful inroads. At the time that Hythloday is describing Utopia, it is not a unified Christian society, but it has been very open to accepting the Christian message. That should not be any surprise given the uncorrupted state of utopian institutions and laws and ideas.

Why would More construct a utopia along these lines? In other words, what's the attraction of this static, rather humdrum, perfect world? What is it that More is running from? Because it seems clear enough that he's not looking towards the future. It's not like a modern utopia which hopes that we will be delivered by science or technology or something else along those lines. It is not forward-looking. More's *Utopia* is essentially a backward-looking gesture at the stasis of medieval Europe. It may not have been just, it may not have been perfect, but at least it stayed the way it was. More was living at a time when the New World has just been discovered and tremendous scientific and technological and religious changes are underway.

Undergirding all of those changes is what we might call the rise of commercial capitalism in the West. This is what scares him. More talks at the beginning of the book about “sheep that eat men.” He is referring to the enclosure movement. That was a movement in English economics and politics which drove people off the land and allowed people to engage in the large-scale wool trade. He describes them as “sheep that eat men.” They eat men because they drive people off the land where they can't eat anymore. The sheep flourish, but people go to cities and die. Terrible evils are being committed.

As a judge, More confronts a system that may condemn such people to death. His protest can be expressed as follows: “No more shall sheep eat men. No more shall commerce drive us into evil.”

In fact, we will restrict our desire for commerce and business and money so that we can achieve morality and political order. What he wants to do is essentially abolish commerce. In a utopian society, gold and silver do not circulate as money, there are no merchants pursuing private gain, and there is no exchange for profit among its citizens. He thinks that when we can get rid of exchange for gain, we will have eliminated not all of human evil, but the greatest predisposition towards human evil. Those other evils that

are left once we create these utopian institutions, well, that residue will be what remains due to the imperfectibility of human beings. In other words, what's left over after you have a perfect society is sin.

All the evils that are still there will be the product of original sin, not the product of corrupt social arrangements. What More is saying in *Utopia* is something along these lines. He's summarizing the entire tradition of Western political philosophy, but he's not a forward-looking thinker who says, this is the next great step.

He's rather saying that we should take a step backwards from where we are. He's saying that the idea of sheep eating men means that our society is disordered and our understanding of right and wrong is disordered. Probably the best way to read More's *Utopia* is as a book of nostalgia for the stasis of the Middle Ages. Although it is in some respects also a jeremiad, a criticism of the present state of society, in fact, his conservatism was insufficient to lead Western Europe into the next stage of political and religious development. His conservatism was backward-looking, and his ideas were inadequate to the job of getting us beyond this fixed and static view of the world. The next great achievement in political and moral thinking in the West will have to forge a new set of ideas and a new set of forward-looking thoughts.

This new set of forward-looking conceptions will emerge only a few years after *Utopia*, in the work of Martin Luther.